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PART 2

PEACEKEEPING EXPERIENCE FROM MEDITERRANEAN COUNTRIES AND THE MIDDLE EAST

THE CULTURE OF PEACE AND PEACEKEEPING OPERATIONS: MIDDLE EAST CASE STUDY⁷⁰

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1. Introduction

The notion of world peace is a relatively recent concept. Not so long ago, every generation worldwide, and Europe in particular, had experienced 'its' war. A certain fatalism with regard to war was ingrained in the human mindset and war was perceived as a virtual inevitability, whilst peace was seen only as a vague utopian dream. The first peace movements of the 20th century were born between the two wars, in the 1920s and 1930s, perhaps culminating in the advent of the League of Nations. Unfortunately, however, the League failed in its quest as the member states did not endow it with the appropriate instruments and powers with which to establish peace. According to some, the rise in nationalist movements of the 19th and 20th centuries that provoked the two world wars played a major role in creating the ideal of world peace; the First World War having claimed the lives of more than 9 million people after which 55 million people died in the Second World War.

Faced with the largest catastrophes in human history, people around the globe began to dream of a better, more peaceful world. The United Nations was established on October 24, 1945, with the aspiration to free the world from the scourge of war. The UN implemented several programmes designed to reduce all the factors perceived to aggravate the outbreak of conflict to the greatest possible extent. These programmes not only focused on peacekeepers who intervene once a conflict has already erupted, but also on economic and social development, human rights, and

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the struggle to end world poverty and hunger. Indeed, all of these United Nations programmes aimed to directly or indirectly prevent conflicts and thus bring peace on earth.

The UN Security Council is the main body of the United Nations, dedicated to the resolution of conflicts and peacekeeping. It is composed of fifteen member states, five of whom are permanent members; China, France, the Russian Federation, the United Kingdom and the United States. The Council is also composed of ten non-permanent members, elected by the General Assembly every two years.

When confronted with a potential threat to international peace and safety, the Security Council first tries to resolve the problem by peaceful means. In the past it has acted as a mediator or, in cases of armed conflict, proposed a cease-fire. The Council can also reinforce its decisions by enacting sanctions, which are a means by which its decisions can be enforced, thereby constituting intervention on a level between that of simple condemnation or armed intervention. Sanctions can also include arms embargoes, trade and finance restrictions, the ceasing of air and sea contact, or diplomatic isolation. Furthermore, the Council can also demand an extension of a mission's manpower and or material capacity.

Until the end of the Cold War, at the outset of the 1990s, the UN only tended to intervene if the conflict involved two or more states. This came to be known as the principle of non-interference. At that time, the principle of state sovereignty was 'officially' adhered to far more than it is today.

The first UN mission, the United Nations Truce Supervision Organization in Palestine (UNTSO), began in 1948 in Palestinian Territory and is still in place. However, the role of such UN missions has undergone considerable change since then. Indeed, UNTSO was only made up of observers mandated to observe whether or not the truce was obeyed. However, at the insistence of Lester B. Pearson, the first United Nations Emergency Force (UNEF I), was set up with a wider mandate during the Suez Canal crisis in 1956. This was the start of veritable peacekeeping missions supported by military, police and civilian contingents.

The role of peacekeepers has further evolved in the post-Cold War period. For various reasons, peacekeeping missions now tend to be operational in a single country. Firstly, international public opinion and

governments are more aware of a country's internal affairs than in the past, as there is greater access to information. Images of extraordinary violence are no longer accepted by the international community. This was the case for Rwanda, Bosnia, Kosovo, East Timor and, more recently, in Sierra Leone. Not so long ago one may even have been unaware that conflicts such as these were taking place, for the simple reason that the world in general was not exposed to such a degree of information.

The establishment by former colonial powers of state models in countries with no such tradition is also central to the development of a peace-keeping culture. Imposition of totally arbitrary borders proved instrumental in bringing different ethnic groups together, some of whom imposed their will on others due to their strength in numbers and educational superiority. Now the situation has evolved and state authorities can no longer dictate to minority groups on their territory. International standards serve to prevent belligerents from committing greater massacres. However, this calls for a stronger, more interventionist approach in defiance of state sovereignty and the principle of non-interference. Peacekeeping missions are thus now required to have greater capabilities in order to accomplish their objectives. They must be able to rebuild, disarm, supervise elections and ensure that human rights are respected. Military intervention is no longer a viable solution. After such missions, democratic institutions that have never existed, or that were destroyed must be rebuilt with the capacity to provide all citizens with equal rights, as in Kosovo and East Timor.

2. UN Peacekeeping Operations

Peacekeeping missions allow the Security Council to watch over the cease-fire and help provide the necessary conditions to achieve peace. On a few rare occasions, it has authorized member states to use all necessary means to keep the peace, including collective military action. According to General Indarjit Riktye, former President of the International Peace Academy, peacekeeping is "the prevention, limitation, moderation and cessation of hostilities between or within states due to the intervention of a third party, which is organized and

directed at the international level and which calls upon military, police and civilian personnel to restore peace.”⁷²

Since 1948 there have been 60 UN peacekeeping operations, of which 47 were created by the United Nations Security Council since 1988. Close to 130 nations have contributed personnel at various times, and 108 are currently providing peacekeepers. As of March 2006, there were 15 peacekeeping operations underway, with a total of almost 90,000 personnel. The top contributors of military and civilian personnel to current missions were Bangladesh (10,255), Pakistan (9,638), India (9,061), and Jordan (3,723).

3. Peacekeeping in the Middle East

Below, table 1 indicates completed peacekeeping operations undertaken by the United Nations in the Middle East, whilst table 2 demonstrates those still in operation.

Table 1:
Completed UN Peacekeeping Operations in the Middle East⁷³

First UN Emergency Force	November 1956 - June 1967
Lebanon	June - December 1958
Yemen	July 1963 - September 1964
Second UN Emergency Force	October 1973 - July 1979
Iran/Iraq	August 1988 - February 1991
Iraq/Kuwait	April 1991 - October 2003

⁷² Cited in “UN and Peacekeeping”, available at <http://www.unac.org/peacecp/factsheet/role.html>

⁷³ Compiled from <http://www.infoplease.com/ipa/A0862135.html>

Table 2:
Current UN Peacekeeping Operations in the Middle East⁷⁴

Middle East	May 1948
Golan Heights	June 1974
Lebanon	March 1978

Both tables show that the Middle East has witnessed ample peacekeeping operations, generally established in an attempt to control the unrest which is perhaps prevalent in the area as a result of Israeli occupation of Arab territories and Israel's intransigence to vacate those territories in tandem with relevant UN resolutions.

Peacekeeping has undergone a transformation during the post-Cold War period. For various reasons, peacekeeping missions which now take place are more frequently operational in a single country. This is firstly because information is more readily acceptable, and also because international public opinion and governments are more aware of a country's internal politics than they were in the past. When images of extraordinary violence now reach the international community, they are not considered acceptable, whether the apparent tension is seemingly religious or ethnic in origin, or whether or not it occurs within a single country. It was not accepted in Rwanda, Bosnia, Kosovo, East Timor, Sierra Leone or, more recently in Lebanon.

4. UNIFIL in Lebanon

The United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL) was established in March 1978 for an initial six-month period. It was intended to help confirm the withdrawal of Israeli forces from southern Lebanon, restore international peace and security, and assist the Lebanese government in ensuring the effective reestablishment of its authority in the area. Since then, UNIFIL's term has been extended continuously, largely as a result of the fragile, unstable situation in Lebanon. Again, on 28 January 1997, its term was extended by the Security Council for a further six-month period, until 31 July 1997. By unanimously adopting resolution 1095 in 1997, the Council reiterated its "strong support for the

⁷⁴ Compiled from <http://www.infoplease.com/ipa/A0862135.html>

territorial integrity, sovereignty and political independence of Lebanon within its internationally recognized boundaries". Also, in condemning "all acts of violence committed in particular against the Force", urging "all parties concerned to cooperate fully with the Force for the full implementation of its mandate" and to end the violence. It encouraged "further efficiency and savings" provided these did not influence UNIFIL's operational capacity.

In his report to the Security Council, the UN Secretary General Kofi Annan set a demarcation line at to confirm Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon⁷⁵ The UN Secretary General endorsed this line of action, whilst the Security Council also stated that "the adoption of this line for the practical purpose of confirming the Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon in compliance with resolution 425 (1978) is without prejudice to any internationally recognized border agreement that Lebanon and the Syrian Arab Republic may wish to conclude in the future". The Security Council has since repeatedly endorsed the Blue Line, calling upon both parties to respect it. The Security Council resolution 1701 (2006), painstakingly negotiated and passed a full month after the hostilities began in Lebanon, established the framework for United Nations efforts to secure an end to the hostilities, which were to be underpinned by a stronger UNIFIL. However, this expanded UNIFIL was intended to buy time, and not to substitute political progress within Lebanon or between Lebanon and its neighbors. The Security Council's adoption of resolution 1559 (2004) was in keeping with its commitment to support Lebanon's sovereignty and territorial integrity, which then led to Syrian withdrawal from Lebanon in the spring of 2005, five years after the Israeli withdrawal.⁷⁶

In his letter of 1 December 2006⁷⁷ the UN Secretary General reported the most recent progress made and outstanding challenges to the effective implementation of Security Council resolution 1701 (2006). He further noted that only the historic achievement of the deployment of the Lebanese army in the area south of the Litani River and along the Blue Line, as well as the crucial role played an expanded UNIFIL, were actually helping the Lebanese army to ensure that the area was "free of armed personnel, assets and weapons other than those of the Government

⁷⁵ UN Doc.S/2000/459, 22 May 2000.

⁷⁶ UN, *Report of the Secretary-General on the Middle East*, UN Doc. S/2006/956, 11 December 2006, p. 10.

⁷⁷ UN Doc. S/2006/933, 1 December 2006.

of Lebanon and those of UNIFIL". He also commended the UNIFIL Maritime Task Force for effectively assisting the Lebanese navy in securing its territorial waters. Recognizing the limitations of peacekeeping activities, the Secretary General nevertheless stressed that such activities could only be effective in a certain, specific political context. The period following the Israeli withdrawal from southern Lebanon until the outbreak of hostilities in the summer of 2006 illustrates the limitations of the monitoring and peacekeeping capabilities of UNIFIL, especially if operating in a sensitive political environment and with limited mandates and resources. Hezbollah's arms build-up during this period was also a constant cause for concern, as are reports that such activities may have continued.

5. Culture of Peace

The first definition of a Culture of Peace was provided by General Assembly resolution A/52/13 which called for a "transformation from a culture of war and violence to a Culture of Peace and non-violence". A Culture of Peace consists of "values, attitudes and behaviors that reflect and inspire social interaction and sharing based on the principles of freedom, justice and democracy, all human rights, tolerance and solidarity, that reject violence and endeavor to prevent conflicts by tackling their root causes to solve problems through dialogue and negotiation and that guarantee the full exercise of all rights and the means to participate fully in the development process of their society." The Program of Action for a Culture of Peace (A/53/243), also adopted by the General Assembly in 1999, encompasses eight program areas: education for a Culture of Peace; equal rights for women; democratic participation; sustainable development; human rights; understanding, tolerance, solidarity; free flow of information and knowledge; international peace and security.⁷⁸ The UN is advised by key organizations reporting on each of these areas.

Some 50 civil society organizations⁷⁹, developed in various Arab countries, strive to establish a Culture of Peace in conflict-affected areas

⁷⁸ UN General Assembly Resolution (A/53/243), 1999.

⁷⁹ There are 50 Civil Society organizations from Algeria, Bahrain, Egypt, Iraq, Lebanon, Jordan, Libya, Morocco, Palestine, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Sudan, Syria, Tunisia and Yemen that are working

of the region. These organizations send their progress reports to the United Nations and, seemingly, the most significant obstacles to progress are the obstinacy of the Israeli government to deny fundamental and national rights to the Palestinian people and the aggressive politics applied by those who call for a violent response.

There are a record number of organizations trying to promote peace in this area. The Palestinian/Israeli project “Good Water Makes Good Neighbors” established by the international NGO ‘Friends of the Earth Middle East’ has achieved concrete and practical reconciliation on the ground. In each community its volunteer youth water trustees centered their efforts on shared water and environmental concerns. A conflict resolution institute in Ramallah has also promoted “peaceful conflict resolution techniques among a generation of future leaders through the design and implementation of unique programs and services ... reaching more than 50,000 beneficiaries in Palestine through the development of relief projects and programmes.”⁸⁰ Despite adverse circumstances in Iraq, a commission for civil society enterprises has established a wide organizational network to coordinate the work and activities of different organizations striving to promote political participation, develop the community’s capabilities and contribute to sustainable development.

Despite their best efforts to establish a Culture of Peace in the conflict-prone areas in the Middle East, the UN agencies and Civil Society organizations, largely established by the Arab world, are faced with following difficulties:

- 1- Insufficient funding;
- 2- Lack of experts in the Culture of Peace;
- 3- Inadequate infrastructure to build capacity, implement projects, ensure sustainability and targeted marketing to enhance civil society and private sector participation in reconstruction exercises;
- 4- Weak cooperation and networking for joint activities;
- 5- Lack of practical coordination on the ground either between international institutions and local NGOs, or between the local NGOs themselves;

for establishing a Culture of Peace in the affected areas of the Middle East, namely Lebanon, Palestine, Iraq, Syria, etc.

⁸⁰ *Youth for Peace Annual Report*, International Peace Academy, Geneva, 2005.

- 6- Local and international media focus on reporting of violence and bombings in the region and indifference to reporting endeavors of organizations engaged in Culture of Peace activities;
- 7- Lack of accurate information-sharing between the Arab world and the West, which has created an unhealthy environment in which to establish a Culture of Peace.

6. Peacekeeping and Intra-Cultural Challenges

Peacekeepers are drawn from different member states of the United Nations as part of the UN Peacekeeping operations in the Middle East. Thus, the peacekeeping force comprises persons hailing from diverse geographic and cultural backgrounds who are assigned the difficult task of maintaining peace under the aegis of the United Nations in different geographic regions with a variety of cultural backgrounds. Such a scenario requires close coordination between peacekeeping and peacemaking activities if the mission is to help achieve lasting peace. Effective peacemaking can establish a cease-fire, at which point peacekeepers may enter to play either a traditional or expanded peacekeeping role.

Impartiality is an essential requirement for peacekeepers. In some recent peacekeeping operations, conventional understanding of impartiality and the use of force have been challenged and attenuated, in part as a result of the more active role peacekeepers are playing in such missions. The more complex the situation, the greater the challenge of retaining the confidence of all parties. In many situations, the possibility of certain parties trying to manipulate the presence of UN peacekeepers to advance their own goals cannot be excluded, particularly in the absence of a clear reconciliation process, or when parties have differing interests in the absence of such a process. Where peacekeepers are involved in inter-state conflict, the UN strives to underline its impartiality to the local population by clearly explaining the role of peacekeepers when they first arrive in the community. Being clear about their aims is an intended means of developing a positive reputation in the local community.

Local support is vital to the success of a peacekeeping force within a conflict-blighted country. Consent and full cooperation can be qualified, particularly in the case of multi-dimensional internal conflicts.

Significant local support must be a prerequisite for the deployment of an international peacekeeping force. If all parties are to remain committed to an agreement on which deployment of a force has been based, they need to believe that their interests are served by that agreement.

If a UN peacekeeping force finds itself losing support from one or more parties to the extent that it is clearly unable to fulfill its original purpose without going on the offensive militarily, it may well have crossed the line from being a peacekeeping operation to being an actor in a peace enforcement mission and must re-evaluate its response accordingly. Sometimes the situation can be more ambiguous, as in Cambodia after the withdrawal of Khmer Rouge from the peace process. In either event, the options open to the UN remain limited. One option could be to change the force's mandate to peace enforcement, recognizing that any mid-stream change of this kind is likely to cause major handicaps for the troops of contributing nations. A second option would be to soldier on in a peacekeeping capacity, re-emphasizing the peacemaking function, thereby potentially risking the safety of the peacekeeping force and creating a hurdle to the peace process indefinitely. The last and most difficult option is to withdraw.

In conflicts in which UN peacekeeping operations have long been ongoing, for example between Israel and its neighbors, the stakes have consistently remained very high, because there is probably no alternative to soldiering on indefinitely. However, in other circumstances the UN may simply have to acknowledge failure and withdraw in order to preserve its credibility and conserve its resources.

The UN peacekeeping forces are multi-national and multi-cultural in composition and nature because the troops are drawn from different member countries willing to contribute forces to that particular mission. Members of each peacekeeping force are also of diverse geographic and cultural backgrounds to the locals of the region to which they are assigned, in efforts to ensure the impartiality of the mission as a whole. This calls for prior understanding by peacekeeping troops of the geographical and cultural background of the region to which they are posted. On top of this, development of this understanding will go a long way towards addressing the issue of cultural interoperability and mission effectiveness in multinational forces. It is thus appropriate that a peacekeeping agreement incorporates a provision for the socio-cultural reorientation of the troops in the region, and such training should be

carried out by the cultural department or civil society organizations of the country in which intervention is to take place.

The Middle Eastern countries are predominantly Muslim and Arabic is usually the *lingua franca*. The region is also rich in Islamic religious and cultural traditions. As deployment of peacekeeping forces in the Middle East is currently a recurring phenomenon, the following suggestions aim to improve the effectiveness of peacekeeping troops in this region:

- 1- The troops designated for peacekeeping operations in the Middle East should preferably be from Islamic countries so that the members are familiar with Islamic tenets and do face minimal difficulties when dealing with local populations;
- 2- If possible, the Arab League should form a 'Peace Force' comprising troops of Arab member countries and some contingents could be borrowed from the League by the United Nations to perform peacekeeping operations when required;
- 3- A similar mechanism can be devised by the International Islamic Conference to help the UN peacekeeping missions in the Middle East;
- 4- A permanent training institute should be established to impart training in cultural traditions to members of UN peacekeeping forces. For deployment of troops in the Middle East, special training in Islamic and Arab cultural traditions could be provided by specifically trained personnel of the Arab League.

7. Conclusion

Establishment of permanent, lasting peace in the Middle East is the goal towards which the United Nations, other key global actors and countries of the Middle East have all inevitably been striving.

Israeli intransigence to vacate the Arab-occupied territories has essentially been the root cause of ongoing tension in the Middle East. In efforts to achieve peace in the region, viable options for both Israel and the Arabs have been considered. Past experience shows that an active and systematic third party role is indispensable. Nevertheless, Israel has traditionally been suspicious of third parties, though the evidence available attests to the fact that an international presence on the ground

has been a key feature of nearly every *modus vivendi* reached between Israel and its adversaries. The Israeli-Syrian border would not be stable without the peacekeepers of the United Nations Disengagement Observer Force. The situation in Hebron, tense and dangerous as it is, would be even worse without the Temporary International Presence. Full disengagement from Gaza would seemingly not have been achieved, had the European Union not stepped in to monitor the Rafah crossing. The Israeli-Hezbollah war of 2006 would probably have taken place much sooner and been yet more explosive had UNIFIL not been present. It would also not have been ended without a reconfigured UNIFIL to help implement Security Council resolution 1701 (2006), full implementation of which appears to be in the interest of all states in the region.⁸¹ Reports indicate growing awareness among Israelis that third parties on the ground can serve Israeli as well as Arab interests, which augurs well for peace, as a stronger third party on the ground may well help bridge gaps, demonstrating that a viable and lasting solution would be beneficial to all parties.

There is a dire need to establish how to pursue an effective, comprehensive regional approach to the conflict. Ultimately, the Arab-Israeli conflict does not require intervention between Israel and the Palestinians alone. The region and diverse strategic priorities of all actors must be fully addressed, as ultimate peace must involve Israel and all its neighbors. One aspect of progress should not be held hostage to another. Israel should consider that comprehensive regional peace may not be achieved without returning the Golan Heights to Syria and at the same time Syria may well be advised to pursue policies demonstrating its commitment to peace and stability in the region, particularly with regard to its immediate neighbors.

⁸¹ For more details, see *United Nations Report of the Secretary-General on the Middle East*, UN Doc. S/2006/956, 11 December 2006, p. 14.

The time is ripe to convene an international conference, along the lines of that held in 1991 in Madrid, to ensure that all regional dimensions of the conflict can be addressed. The revival of the regional track of the peace process, which is a *sine qua non* of the road map to peace, is in the interests of all. It is high time for all the parties concerned to work to ensure that conditions in the region favor the establishment of peace, thereby laying substantive foundations for trust, successful negotiations and peace in the region.